

Privacy: What Not to Share — and Why

Helping your child understand personal information, and make confident choices about sharing online.

Why this matters

Posting, messaging and reacting happen fast, often without a second thought. What's less visible is what happens *after* something is shared: it can be screenshotted, reshared beyond the intended audience, stored by platforms, and quietly added to a longer-term digital footprint. This doesn't mean children should stop sharing — it means they need support to understand how information travels, and how to stay in control of it.

52.8%

of young people in Sri Lanka access the internet — average age of first access is just 13

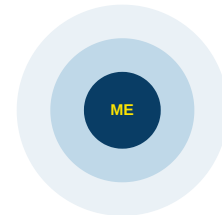
28%

of children in Sri Lanka report experiencing online violence, like indecent messages or links

14%

of Sri Lankan youth have had a fake account created in their name online

Not everything is all-or-nothing: there are layers of sharing



- Close friends — the inner circle
- Wider group — classmates, followers
- Anyone — the open, public layer

What counts as "personal information"

Children usually recognise a full name or home address as private. They notice less often that small, casual details add up to the same thing:

- 1 Photos that show where they are** — street signs, house numbers, recognisable landmarks in the background.
- 2 School uniforms & badges** — enough for a stranger to work out which school, and when to find them.
- 3 Casual chat details** — "I'm home alone", "I go to..." — said in the moment, on WhatsApp or group chats, without thinking twice.
- 4 Location tags & live sharing** — showing exactly where someone is, right now.
- 5 Usernames & handles** — on TikTok, Instagram or gaming apps that quietly include a birth year, school, or real name.
- 6 Voice notes, purchases & browsing activity** — less obvious data that still builds a personal profile.

Ask before you post

Rules like "don't overshare" work less well than good judgement. Help your child pause and ask:

Who is this really **for**?

Could this be seen by **more people** than I expect?

Where risk creeps in

Most sharing is harmless. Risk tends to show up as:

- **Unwanted contact** from strangers
- **Privacy loss** beyond the intended audience
- **Social pressure** or posts taken out of context — in a class group or WhatsApp chat

A longer-term footprint that shapes how others see them

START WITH THESE THREE CHECKS

- ☐ Does your child understand that small pieces of information can add up to a lot?
- ☐ Do they feel confident deciding what's okay to share, and with whom?
- ☐ Have you talked about how sharing can spread beyond who it was meant for?

GOOD TO KNOW

Sri Lanka's **Online Safety Act, No. 9 of 2024** criminalises the distribution of child sexual abuse material, with penalties of up to 20 years' imprisonment, and the **Personal Data Protection Act, No. 9 of 2022** sets rules for how companies handle personal data — including children's.

If you're ever worried about a child's safety online, the National Child Protection Authority's Childline is free, 24 hours, in Sinhala, Tamil and English.

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